

Set up the tags

Five minutes, once per machine. OneNote stores tags on the computer, not in the notebook — so every scribe does this on their own laptop.

THE SIX TAGS TO CREATE, IN THIS ORDER

KEY	NAME	SYMBOL	FONT	HIGHLIGHT	WHAT IT IS FOR
Ctrl+1	Ruled out	Red cross / X	Red	None	<i>The workhorse. Reason on the same line.</i>
Ctrl+2	Can't miss	Exclamation mark	Red	None	<i>Named by the PGY-1, first pass.</i>
Ctrl+3	Discriminating test	Magnifier / arrow	Green	None	<i>One per board. Never two.</i>
Ctrl+4	Pending	Clock	Green	None	<i>Still open at 0:25. Searchable later.</i>
Ctrl+5	Teaching point	Light bulb	Black	Yellow	<i>Take-homes and faculty adds.</i>
Ctrl+6	Bias watch	Eye / question	Black	Yellow	<i>Named out loud by the senior.</i>

HOW

1. Open OneNote for Windows desktop. Home tab > Tags group > click the More arrow at the lower right of the tag gallery > Customize Tags.
2. Click New Tag. Enter the display name, pick the symbol, set the font colour and highlight colour from the table above. Click OK. Repeat for all six.
3. Now put them in order. Select each new tag and use the Up button to move it into positions 1 through 6. Position is what assigns the shortcut — anything in the first nine slots gets Ctrl+1 through Ctrl+9.
4. The built-in To Do and Important tags will get pushed down. That is fine; you are not using them here.
5. Test it: type a line, press Ctrl+1, and confirm you get a red cross and red text.

TWO THINGS TO KNOW BEFORE YOU ROLL THIS OUT

Tags are per-machine, so a rotating scribe means repeated setup. If that friction is going to kill it, nominate one board laptop per site that always scribes, or skip tags entirely and use plain strikethrough plus a typed em-dash reason — the convention matters more than the tooling. Full tag management is Windows desktop only: OneNote for the web can apply and search tags, but cannot create or reorder them.

Scribe quick reference

Print this and keep it beside the keyboard. Six keys and one convention are the whole job.

Ctrl+1

Ruled out
Red cross / X · red text

Ctrl+2

Can't miss
Exclamation mark · red text

Ctrl+3

Discriminating test
Magnifier / arrow · green text

Ctrl+4

Pending
Clock · green text

Ctrl+5

Teaching point
Light bulb · black text

Ctrl+6

Bias watch
Eye / question · black text

THE ONE CONVENTION THAT MATTERS

Ctrl+1, then type — and the reason.

A ruled-out diagnosis with no reason beside it teaches nothing. The reason is the entire point of striking it. If the group has not given you one, ask: “what argues against it?” — that question is part of the scribe's job, not an interruption.

LOOKS LIKE THIS

X Transient synovitis — febrile at 38.6 and refusing to bear weight, three of four Kocher

OTHER KEYS WORTH KNOWING

- Alt + Hyphen

Strikethrough. Optional — the red tag already marks it, and tagged text stays legible on a screen share where struck text does not.
- Ctrl + 0

Remove all tags from the selected line.
- Home › Find Tags

Pulls every tagged item across the whole notebook into one pane. A year of ruled-out diagnoses, with reasons, in one list.
- Ctrl + E

Search every notebook. This is how the board becomes the case bank.

Type the content, ink the annotation. Typed text is what searches, exports and feeds the case bank. Circles and arrows are for live thinking and do not need to survive.